Part 4: Tie-Breaking Essay

These notes are not intended to be understood as a key for the Tie-Breaking Essay prompt; rather, they should serve the judge(s) as a presentation of critical ideas that might appear in an essay responding to the prompt.

Criteria for judging the Tie-Breaking Essay **SHOULD** include

the degree to which the instructions have been followed,

the quality of the critical insight offered in response to the selection,

the overall effectiveness of the written discussion, and

the grammatical correctness of the essay.

Note well that the quality of the contestant's critical insight is more important than the contestant's prose style. In short, the Literary Criticism contest is one that promotes the critical analysis of literature. The quality of the writing, which should never go unappreciated, does not trump evidence of critical analysis.

Critical Notes on Robert Browning's "Love in Life"

Literary concepts that **MIGHT** be used in a discussion of the psychology of memory in Browning's "Love in Life" include

alliteration,
allusion,
anaphora (internal),
apostrophe,
conceit,
controlling image,
feminine rhyme,
imagery,
liminality,
line length,
metaphor,
meter,
metonymy,
paradox,
rhopalic,
theme,
threshold, and
tone.

The contestant might remain with the literal pursuit, the "hunt" of line 2, or she might recognize the hunt as a controlling image (extended metaphor) that pervades the poem's two stanzas. In either case, the optimism appears to be driven by the speaker's memory of what love is or what love should be, especially as it is understood in terms of a single lover (girlfriend) or, perhaps, looking for another lover. The house might be seen in the literal sense or in the figurative, the hunt through the house with its many rooms and doors as a journey through life with its many relationships (or stages of relationships) and its many thresholds—the poem's theme of liminality. The imagery that reinforces the controlling image, the hunt as a journey, and that makes the connection between the first and second stanzas is found in the metaphorical "the day wears" and "door succeeds door." The speaker is getting older, and the journey's timeframe (line 15: "'tis twilight") is closing; the hunt is getting less localized as it moves into the fullness of the house.

The memories evoked and represented by both the perfume and the reflection in the mirror become the catalysts for his continued search. Memory, inferred through the several images of succession, especially the speaker's apparent experience with/knowledge of suites, closets, and alcoves seems to drive/entice the speaker to complete his quest, as if this quest is either a new one—based on memorable experience—or a continued quest.

The student might, after the contests of course, compare Browning's "Love in Life" with Adele's "Chasing Pavements," noting that "chasing pavements" is a British colloquialism for a "fruitless activity" including, perhaps, finding or hunting for love. Regarding Browning's own poetry: this poem might be an easy way into a study of "Childe Roland to the Dark Tower Came."